

with heated discussions on “The Hobbit” and the accompanying quiz. But as soon as they spot Zeenat, the kids switch to barraging her with questions about the movie and how they felt the actors could have been directed better, or how the story will unfold in the next instalment of the movie. This gives Zeenat a brainwave! Knowing that the kids will be visiting the school’s spartan computer lab in a couple

of hours, she sets aside 15 minutes from the day’s schedule for the kids to write letters (well emails to be more precise) to Peter Jackson on how the movie could be “improved” and what they expect out of him in for the next movie! She asks them to deliberately introduce spelling errors, and see if the word-processing software can catch them, before they actually shoot off their emails to Mr. Jackson.



Movietime! 4th grade students watch *The Jungle Book* movie before reading the book in English class

Possibilities: Gamification in action

A New York based school is trying a unique approach at learning. Designed by promoters who have a background in game design, Quest to Learn re-imagines school as one node in an ecology of learning and engages kids in ways that are exciting, empowering and culturally relevant.

Each semester, students encounter a series of increasingly complex, narrative challenges, games or quests, where learning, knowledge sharing, feedback, reflection and next steps emerge as a natural function of play. For instance, in the integrated science and math learning domain, “The Way Things Work,” over the course of one semester, sixth graders help a shrunken mad scientist, lost inside the human body, navigate the systems he encounters and report back to his research lab. This is called “gamification,” a fast adopted system of applying game elements and game design techniques to school teaching. It plays on the human instinct to compete and earn rewards.

Other unique components of Quest to Learn include an embedded learning design studio called “Mission Lab” where game-based curricula and other learning materials are developed, such that they are supportive of key twenty-first century competencies, like systems thinking, creative problem-solving, collaboration, and time management. A mixed-reality learning environment, called “SMALLab”, uses motion-capture cameras, short-throw projectors and wireless controllers to immerse players in dynamic game-based scenarios, where they can interact with each other and digital game elements in real time in shared physical space. “Short Circuit” is an after-school hands-on laboratory designed to help participants to explore innovative uses for physical and digital materials, like circuits, conductive inks, LEDs, the latest programming languages, paper, pipe cleaners, iPads, etc. (*Watch this video:* <http://vimeo.com/21043303>)



A teachers questioning a students about aspects of his own game elements



Students play a game by a fellow student and provide peer feedback

Video Diaries

The day then begins with a “Speaking and Listening” session, where students are assigned on a daily rotational basis to either read a piece of news or a topic of their choice. Today, Ganesh, one of the naughtier students, goes up to the front of the class and reads out a short poem which last night’s movie inspired him to write. Zeenat records this on her mobile phone using its built in 10 megapixel camera. She plans to share some of the videos with an online community of child psychologists and behaviour experts to try and and get some insight into a couple of kids, who she expects have learning disabilities. With the help of a volunteer, Zeenat also hopes to make video diaries of each student over the school year, which she will then use to present her students with their own progress, and also get their parents (most of whom are daily wage earners) invested in their children’s learning.

Phonics and Pronunciation

The first session completed, it is now time for a Phonics lesson. Zeenat turns on her laptop and the ceiling-mounted projector (donated by a philanthropic trust). The aim in this session is to improve the reading fluency of the kids, for most of whom English is a second or third language. This is achieved by simultaneously honing three critical skills: visual decoding of a word, aural recognition, and vocal reproduction. Zeenat plays a video that shows the spellings of different words, an associated illustration, and a video of a demonstrator’s facial muscles as he speaks that word aloud. The accompanying audio is played through laptop-connected speakers.